

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH  
*of Los Angeles*

*Pride Sunday*

*The Many Faces of God*

*31 May 2026*



*Photographer Unknown*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020  
Telephone 213.385.1341 – [www.FCCLA.org](http://www.FCCLA.org)

## **The Gathering of the People**

*First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~*

*Please note that our services are live streamed at [fccla.org/live](http://fccla.org/live).*

### **Organ Prelude Concert**

**Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence**

Improvisation on SLANE and ABBOT'S LEIGH

Meditation on *Ave Maris Stella* (Gregorian Chant)

Somewhere Over The Rainbow (Harold Arlen & Yip Harburg, adapted by C. Bull)

**Camas High School Select Vocal Ensemble, Ethan Chessin, Director**

Geistliches Lied, Op. 30 (Johannes Brahms)

**Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence**

*Ave Maris Stella* (Mark Thomas)

Rise Stronger (J. Neumann & T. Hudson)

### **Chiming of the Hour**

#### **Welcome**

**Rev. Laura Vail Fregin**

#### **Words of Gathering**

**Ayur Barduev and Dr. Matthew White**

Listen! Listen! The Divine names us all:  
*Holy, Beloved, Cherished, Valued!*

In the image of God, we were created and called good.  
In abundant diversity, God's likeness is found.  
*We believe God delights in us and all creation!*

Holy One, may we be those who recognize and proclaim  
your beauty and goodness in unexpected places and people.  
*Surprise us, challenge us, transform us!*

Reveal to us the sacredness of every life,  
of our unique ways of being,  
of every physical manifestation of your Spirit,  
*as we reject all messages that belittle or degrade any among us.*

God calls each of us:  
out of the places we hide,  
out of insecurities,  
out of shame,  
out from under that which silences love and justice.  
*Come out, people of God! God calls us to courage!*

-adapt. from M. Jade Kaiser

May it be so.  
*May it be so for all of us!*

*Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering*

**\*Hymn of Gathering**

*All the Colors of the Rainbow*

ABBOT'S LEIGH

All the colors of the rainbow live unseen in daily light,  
But their splendors find expression when released to human sight;  
So the church reveals most beauty where diversity is real:  
Breadth of race and class and gender, room for doubt and space to heal.

All the body's parts are wanted, nor can one despise the rest:  
Head and hand must work together, as must eye and ear and chest;  
So the church needs all its members for a range of ministries:  
Varied gifts with one great mission, "Do this for the least of these."

Every language gains more music when the words for peace appear:  
Pax, Salaam, Eirini, Heiwa, Pace, Santi, Frieden, Mir.  
Though our tongues make sounds that vary all bespeak a common home:  
Longing for the end of conflict and a new life in God's Shalom.

Teach us, God, our need of others; through them help us fully live.  
Wean us from our selfish habits; let us listen, learn, forgive.  
May we see your longed-for image in each human heart and face,  
And behold how those around us can be channels of your grace.

**\*Prayer of Awareness**

**Rev. Michael Lehman**

God of wild love and extravagant acceptance,  
Spirit of boldness and beauty,  
You are faithfully present in both the grit and glitter of life,  
and you are present here with us now.

Awaken us to your dream for creation:  
*A world in which every member of the human family is free  
to flourish however you have made them.*

Forgive us for the moments we have held back  
your ever-flowing current of love, dignity, and justice.  
*Remake us into a people eager to see you  
in the faces, bodies, and expressions of all people.*

Remind each of us to emerge from the shadows of our lives  
and shine fearlessly and courageously.  
*Ignite the Divine Light within us to sparkle through the prism  
of our bodies and brighten every corner of this Earth.*

Holy One, You call each of us beloved.  
*Each of us cherished.  
Each of us desired.*

*Each of us sacred.  
And so, we give you thanks, now and forever.*

*-adapt. from Rev. Sam Lundquist*

*May it be so.  
May it be so for all of us.  
Amen and Amen!*

**\*Introit**

**"Step By Step"**

ANNIE LENNOX

Lorenzo Zapata, *Soloist*, combined choirs, Dr. David Harris, *Conductor*

**\*The Lord's Prayer**

**Sonnie Swenston**

*Holy Being,  
whom we call by many different names,  
Blessed are you,  
Blessed are we in you.  
May we create with you  
a realm of mercy, peace, and justice.  
May love be done in the here and now,  
as it is in the infinite.  
May we share life in bread and hope.  
For our failure to love, we need forgiveness.  
May we find the paths of reconciliation.  
In the midst of evil's incarnation,  
from the powers that have power over our spirits  
and our structures, may we find liberation.  
In the power that is love,  
we seek to live and move and have our being.  
May it be so,  
now and forever.  
Amen and Amen.*

[nancylsteeves]

**\*Gloria Deo**

*Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,  
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.  
World without end, Amen, Amen.*

**\*Passing of the Peace**

**Rev. Fregin**

*In the beauty of this day and in the light of the rainbow  
that shines over this gathered community,  
let us remember that our God is always and forever  
with us, and for us!*

*May the Peace and Love of God be with you all.  
And also with you!*

*You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow*

*Please be seated*

### **Children's Conversation**

**Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack**

Following this conversation, children are invited to join us for our Sunday morning programming. If you were unable to check in your children prior to the service, please accompany them to our Children's Area and check them in before returning to the service. Children must be picked up after worship before you head to the Pride Festival in the Forecourt.

### **Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition** *from Genesis, chapter 1*

**Sonnie Swenston**

For these words of wisdom from our ancestors,  
*Thanks be to God!*

### **Musical Gift**

*"Colors Of The Wind"* ALAN MENKEN & STEPHEN SCHWARTZ  
Christin Byrdsong, *Soloist*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*

### **Prayers with the People**

**Rev. Fregin**

### **Invitation to Silence and Prayer**

A strong rainbow pours itself out,  
bending the eastern sky with glory,  
it brings with it a powerful beauty  
to soothe my needy heart with hope.

And I do believe I hear the sun  
wild with wonder and rejoicing,  
laughing at the once-darkened sky  
now parted in colored splendor.

I remember then the One who came,  
who broke our stormy night apart,  
and shook despairing hearts with hope;  
this One told truth of things beyond  
and gave us more than gold.

This rainbow filling late-June sky  
touches more than just the earth;  
it makes its mark within my depth  
and lets my heart look up in hope.  
-Joyce Rupp

### ***Silence***

### **Musical Gift**

*"Nancy"*  
Rev. Michael Lehman, *Marimba*

EMMANUEL SÉJOURNÉ

### **Prayer of Our Hearts**

Wondrous God, lover of lion and lizard,  
cedar and cactus, raindrop and river,  
we give thanks for the splendor of this, your world!  
We thank you that woven in the tapestry of earth  
are the varied threads of incredible diversity.

Created in Your image, we are of many colors and cultures, ages  
and classes, sexualities and gender identities.  
Different and alike, we are your beloved people.  
Free us, we pray, from fears of difference  
that divide and wound us.

Move us to dismantle our attitudes and systems of prejudice.  
Renew our commitment to make this a community for all people –  
that all who encounter and share life here  
may know the grace and challenge of faith.  
In our life together, grant us minds and hearts eager to learn,  
reluctant to judge, and responsive to the leading of Your loving Spirit.  
-adapt. Rev. Ann B. Day

We pray all of this may be so.  
*Amen and Amen!*

**Meditation Anthem**

*“When the Earth Stands Still”*

DON MACDONALD

Laude and Camas High School Select Vocal Ensemble, Ethan Chessin, *Conductor*

**Sermon**

*The Many Faces of God*

**Rev. Tanaka Pack**

**Invitation to Generosity**

**Ayur Barduev**

*At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at [fccla.org/give](http://fccla.org/give). Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.*

**Offertory**

*“Ev’ry Time I Feel The Spirit”*

WILLIAM DAWSON

Combined Choirs, Dr. Ernest H. Harrison, *Conductor*, John Musselman, *Soloist*

*“Somewhere Over The Rainbow”* HAROLD ARLEN AND YIP HARBURG  
Molly Pease, *Soloist* and Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*

**\*Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,  
let the Creator’s praise arise!  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Your name shall sound and praises soar  
till suns shall rise and set no more.  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

**\*Offering Prayer**

**Dr. Matthew White**

Holy God, we are your people, created in your image.  
In our diversity we have strength;  
in our shared humanity a common hope,  
a vision of life unbound by time.

We have come together to celebrate,  
to reflect, and to recommit ourselves to your work.

Shake us out of our complacency,  
rock our comfortable certainties  
and challenge us to recognize the face of the Christ  
in the eyes of everyone we meet.

May our hearts be open to the challenge  
of your call to true freedom,  
our minds and hands ready  
to grasp the opportunity for change.

*Inspire us with your message,  
open us to the joy of your word,  
and guide us as we prepare  
to answer your call to open our doors  
even wider in this place, we call home.*

May it be so, O God.  
*May it be so for all of us.*  
*Amen and Amen.*

*Please be seated*

**Life at First Church**

**Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman**

**Words of Blessing**

**Rev. Tanaka Pack**

As we leave this place,  
let us remember and exclaim who we are...

*We are the people who heal each other,  
who grow strong together,  
who know what it means  
to live in community,  
moving towards a common dream  
for a world filled with inclusiveness,  
compassion, and generosity,  
found in the power of the love of God,  
the company of the Christ,  
and the leading of the Holy Spirit.*

Go now in peace,  
as those who walk a common way,  
and may you find others  
to walk on this path with you.  
May the hospitality you share  
return to you through the love of God  
both this day, and forevermore.

*May it be so both now,  
all in all the days to come!*

## Choral Response

*"Tshotsholoza"* SOUTH AFRICAN WORK SONG, arr. JEFFREY L. AMES  
Combined Choirs, Markus Ruddy, *Soloist*, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

## \*Hymn for the Journey

## *God of Many Faces*

SLANE

God of many faces, we offer our praise,  
Singing your glory through all of our days.  
Hear ever growing voices, once fragile, now strong,  
Carrying melodies in expansive new songs.

God of many genders, our world reflects you,  
Sunrise and sunset uniting our hues,  
woven into a city with jewels of all shades,  
Houses of ruby and walls rowed with jade.

God of many names, we invite you to show  
Us the new names that reflect our true souls.  
Breathe with your holy spirit to give us the Word  
That will indwell dry bones, grating new life once heard.

God of many bodies, abide within ours,  
Shifting more each day through time and through scars.  
Come sanctify our bodies, all fashioned by you,  
Holier every day, still becoming more true.

-Lyrics by Amy Cerniglia

## Postlude

**Dr. Christoph Bull**, *Organist-in-Residence*  
Fuga in C (Alessandro Scarlatti)

TBD

**Inside The Music**

**Dr. David Harris**